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Over 400 Celebrate Grand Opening and Dedication of ACF Sarkis & Suzan Kitsinian Youth Center

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15-Year Community Effort Transforms Former Fire Station 83 into a Permanent Home for Youth, Culture, and Service

ENCINO, Calif.—The Grand Opening and Dedication Ceremony of the Armenian Cultural Foundation Sarkis & Suzan Kitsinian Youth Center was celebrated on January 18, marking the culmination of a 15-year community effort to establish a permanent home for Armenian youth, culture, and civic service in the San Fernando Valley.

More than 400 community members, faith leaders, elected officials, and organizational representatives gathered to witness the transformation of the former Fire Station 83 into a revitalized community anchor on Balboa Boulevard.

The dedication began with a Flag Ceremony by the Homenetmen Massis chapter, followed by the U.S. National Anthem performed by Young Idols Singing Studio and the Armenian National Anthem performed by members of the AYF Sardarabad Chapter and Simon Vratzian Juniors.

Western Prelate Archbishop Kegham Khacherian, was joined by Archbishop Moushegh Mardirossian and Archpriest Razmig Khachadourian, pastor of the Holy Martyrs Armenian Church in offering the blessing and invocation over the newly opened center.

A Historic Gathering Of Leaders

The ceremony brought together a distinguished assembly of leaders, including U.S. Representative Brad Sherman; California State Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel; Los Angeles City Councilmember Nithya Raman; former Los Angeles Mayor and former U.S. Ambassador to India Eric Garcetti; former Los Angeles City Council President Paul Krekorian; former Los Angeles City Councilmember Paul Koretz; and additional civic, faith, and community leaders.

Former L.A. Mayor Eric Garcetti

Former Mayor Garcetti, whose support in obtaining the center was unwavering during his tenure as Councilmember and later as Mayor, underscored the importance of building institutions that safeguard identity and memory. "In this time when so much of history gets erased so quickly," he said, "this is a community… [that] not only cannot be erased, but must not be erased."

The Kitsinian Family

At the heart of the day's celebration was the recognition of the Youth Center's principal benefactors, Sarkis and Suzan Kitsinian and their family. Master of Ceremonies Shant Hagopian, Esq. opened the formal program by honoring their lifelong commitment to Armenian communal life and American civic engagement.

Sarkis & Suzan Kitsinian and family

"Sarkis and Suzan Kitsinian have been lifelong supporters and benefactors of our community and its organizations," Hagopian said, recognizing their decades of leadership and philanthropy and their commitment to investing in the next generation through this Youth Center. Throughout the program, civic and community leaders praised the Kitsinian family's generosity and long-standing commitment to philanthropy.

Meaningfully, the Grand Opening and Dedication of the Center fell on what would have been the 159th birthday of Stepan Zorian, better known by his nom de guerre Rosdom, one of the three founders of the Armenian Revolutionary Federation and the namesake of the local ARF Rosdom Gomideh, of which Sarkis Kitsinian has been an active member of since settling in Encino in 1988. The opening of a youth center on Rosdom's birthday is a continuation of that same vision. He was the only ARF founder to witness an independent Armenia; fittingly, this center ensures that the next generation will be prepared to build upon that inheritance.

Building With Heart: Community, Partnership, And A Shared Purpose

ACF-WSFV and Rosdom Gomideh Chair, Raffi Sarkissian delivered an emotional account of the fifteen-year effort to bring the center to fruition.

ARF Rosdom Gomideh Chair Raffi Sarkissian

"It all started about 15 years ago when a group of young Armenian National Committee members had the vision, under the leadership of the local ARF, to convert this old fire station that was abandoned into a community center," Sarkissian recalled.

He reflected on the long path from vision to reality—one shaped by perseverance through zoning, historical landmark requirements, and extensive environmental and governmental processes. The result, he noted, was a 30-year lease that secured the site as a community home, and a project carried across the finish line by collective effort and steadfast partners.

Ribbon cutting for the Nazerian Family Hall with Vartan Nazerian and family, Western Prelate Archbishop Kegham Khacherian, and ACF-WSFV Chair Raffi Sarkissian

General Contractor Vartan Nazerian of the Nazerian Group, who came out of retirement to help complete the renovation within the organization's limited budget and absorb major overruns, was recognized for his contribution. With gratitude, the ACF-WSFV named the center's hall as the "Nazerian Family Hall."

Dedication of the Haig Diradourian Room with Members of the ARS Anahid Chapter

In memory of Haig Diradourian, who passed away in his early twenties, the AYF room has been dedicated through a $90,000 donation from the Armenian Relief Society Anahid Chapter, through the Khatun Shakarian Memorial Fund, established in memory of her grandson.

Unprecedented Public Support, A Vision For The Future

The opening of the Youth Center was marked by an outpouring of support from local, state, and federal leaders, reflecting the project's significance not only to the Armenian community but to the broader civic fabric of the San Fernando Valley. Elected officials and community leaders highlighted the center as a model of partnership, perseverance, and public service, and emphasized its role in shaping future generations.

Rep. Brad Sherman

Congressman Brad Sherman highlighted the successful effort to secure a $1.2 million federal HUD grant for construction—an unprecedented achievement for the organization. "I went to the Appropriations Committee and they said, 'Sherman, you only get a few of these a year,'" Sherman recalled. "'And I said, 'This is at the top of my list.'"

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, an Encino resident, praised the community's tenacity and the center's meaning for future generations: "For me, there is no better symbol of resilience than building a center that will serve your youth, that will serve the next generation."

Councilmember Nithya Raman reflected on the transformation of the site: "It has gone from a blight to a blessing for Encino," she said, commending the community's persistence and civic partnership in restoring the historic structure.

Former Councilmember Paul Koretz, who championed the project from its earliest days, called the center "a beacon of goodwill" and emphasized that it will serve not only Armenians, but the broader Valley community through art, language, and cultural programs.

Former Council President Paul Krekorian framed the milestone as the beginning of a new chapter: "What matters more than this building is what happens inside of this building," he said, envisioning a future of lifelong friendships, strengthened identity, and service nurtured within the center's walls.

Central Committee Board Chair Garo Madenlian summarized the community's guiding formula with a call that resonated across generations: "Church. School. Community Center… That's the family we defend. That's the family we represent. And that's the family that we grow."

A Pledge To Secure The Center's Future

Nareg Kitsinian, Esq., Opening Committee Chair delivered the ceremony's closing address.

Opening Committee Chair and Member of the Kitsinian Family, Nareg Kitsinian, Esq

"Were we dreaming? Were we delusional or crazy?" Kitsinian asked. "Clearly not. We had a goal. We had a vision. And the determination to make it real."

Kitsinian honored those who carried the mission forward, including community leaders, government partners and others before sharing his heartfelt remarks and announcement.

"Tonight is especially meaningful for me and my family, as this center now bears the name of my parents and family," Kitsinian said. "Mom and Dad, this is a tribute to your sacrifice, your vision, and love of our people."

Kitsinian announced the creation of a restricted fund dedicated solely for the eventual purchase of the property—an effort intended to secure a permanent future beyond the current lease term. On behalf of himself and his wife, Ani, he announced the fund's initial seed donation of $100,000.

The Youth Center's Mission

The ACF Sarkis & Suzan Kitsinian Youth Center will serve as a home for ACF's sister organizations—including local chapters of the Armenian Revolutionary Federation, Armenian National Committee, Armenian Youth Federation, Armenian Relief Society, Homenetmen, and Hamaskayin—and will function as a disaster preparedness hub for the greater Encino community, a gesture of goodwill and appreciation to the City of Los Angeles and its officials who championed the community's cause.

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